

Is It Just You?

A two-minute customer story. Deadpan testimonial, filmed across Leeds, from a workshop to the ballroom at the Queens Hotel.

The principle. Marek fits sash windows on his own, and everyone asks him the same thing before they book: is it just you. So he asked Code Overlord for a website with a team page, then for the software behind it, which he called Head Office, and then kept going back and asking it to wire Head Office into one more real thing, until Head Office was running the firm, and then a good deal more than the firm.

Why it is funny. He wanted what a proper firm has and he got all of it, first time, every time. He is completely sincere about every decision in it, including the ones his own software makes for him.

Marek fits sash windows. Jean on Cardigan Road rang about hers.

"She said, is it just you."

"What did you say?"

"Yes." A pause. "She rang somebody else."

In the workshop he typed one sentence.

"I wanted to look like a proper firm. So I asked Code Overlord for a website with a team page. It were up by the Thursday. Enquiries tripled. But the team page had three empty squares. So I asked Code Overlord for staff."

Windows opened under his sentence. By Monday there was HEAD OFFICE, with a letterhead: NOWAK & SONS across the top, headofficeleeds.com along the bottom.

"Have you got sons?"

"One." A pause. "He's four."

He wrote the departments himself, in plain English. Sales, Vincent: be keen, take a hundred off for cash. Support, Adrian: whatever it is, it's our fault. Operations, Halina: protect the diary, don't ask me, just book it.

"Halina were my nan. She were like that."

Then faces, on the timer.

"Is that Halina?"

"That's her cardigan."

"Is that you in it?"

A pause. "It's her cardigan."

At four in the morning Adrian writes to a man whose sash fell on his hand. *You are completely right to be angry. It isn't our window, but it is our fault.* The man books a survey.

"They all book a survey. So I had Code Overlord make Adrian sorrier every Sunday, and put him on the front page. For anybody in Leeds. Whatever it is."

SOMETHING WRONG IN LEEDS? TELL ADRIAN. Leeds does. The potholes. A man in Pudsey gets an apology for the Wars of the Roses.

"On whose behalf?"

"The firm's."

"How many letters?"

"Forty-one thousand. Nine were about windows. He's apologised for the tram."

"What tram?"

"Exactly. He took full responsibility."

Leeds City Council write to thank him, and ask when the tram will be done.

"What did you tell them?"

"Nothing. Halina's booked it in."

"How long for?"

"Twenty-six years."

"Who's doing it?"

"Me." A pause. "Then our lad."

"What was the deposit?"

"Four point one million. Contactless. So I asked Code Overlord for a Christmas do. Like a proper firm has."

The ballroom at the Queens Hotel, two hundred chairs and a Robbie Williams from Pontefract. At the top table, place cards for Vincent, Adrian and Halina, a bread roll each.

"How many came?"

"Me."

"Where were you sat?"

"Table nineteen."

Robbie sings Angels to three bread rolls. On the screen, Employee of the Year: Vincent, which is Marek in a tie.

"Were you nominated?"

"I'm not staff."

Lifetime Achievement: Halina. Nobody moves.

"Somebody had to."

He collects it in her cardigan, under a photograph of himself in it, and Operations adds one more slide. The only thing holding up the tram is the fitter, eight minutes slow on every sash. ROLE AT RISK: FITTER (FOUNDER).

"What did you do?"

"Thanked her." A pause. "It's Lifetime Achievement."

The redundancy letter comes on the Monday, dated the twentieth of December 2027. He appeals. Adrian replies within the hour.

"It isn't your firm, but it is our fault."

"Did you get a package?"

"Statutory. Vincent took a hundred off for cash."

Jean rings again.

"She said, is it just you."

"What did you say?"

"Yes." A pause. "She rang Head Office."

"Did they fit her in?"

"After the tram."

"Would you recommend it?"

"Code Overlord? It's never once got it wrong." A pause. "Operations can be difficult." A pause. "She were like that."

The Otley Road, in the rain. At the tram line, in a hi-vis down to his wellies, a four-year-old. Halina has brought him forward. Marek holds the umbrella.

Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One sentence typed, windows opening underneath it, a website by Thursday. An app he named himself, with three departments he wrote in plain English, each with its own name, face and instructions. A prompt on a cadence, every Sunday, that makes one of them sorrier. A box on the front page, open to the whole city. And after that, Head Office writing, booking, charging and letting him go, with nobody at the laptop at all.

Accent. The whole cast, the interviewer included, is West Yorkshire, Leeds, and nobody is neutral. The accent lives in the grammar, never the spelling: "were" for "was" in every person, "sat" for "sitting", "our lad". The Robbie from Pontefract is the same accent, pushed. Head Office never speaks; everything it says is on paper or a screen.

Condensed from a longer version that went through two comedians' panels; the long version is kept.

Three things to decide. The last shot: the four-year-old at the tram line after "She were like that", as written, or cut to the card on her line, which saves about ten seconds. Keep it, because it pays off "Then our lad". Adrian's history apology: the Wars of the Roses, as written, or the 1939 version Jimmy Carr

offered, apologising to a Polish widow in Moortown, which is the bigger laugh and the bigger risk. Keep the Wars of the Roses for a brand film. The title: *Is It Just You?* over *Head Office*, because it is the question the film turns on. He says yes at the start and loses the job, and yes at the end, and his own firm gets it.